

RHUBARB *Rheum x hybridum* syn. *R. cultorum*

Rhubarb is an anomaly; it is a vegetable that is eaten as a fruit, and one that produces plenty of tasty stalks at a time of year when little else is available, especially if “forced.” Although it can get by with little care and attention, it repays generous treatment with greater yields of better produce. Unlike most vegetable crops, it is perennial, and can give several years of productive growth before it needs to be replaced.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Rhubarb prefers an open site and should be planted in soil that has been improved with plenty of manure or other bulky organic matter—it needs soil that will drain well, but not become waterlogged. Additional balanced fertilizer is helpful and should be applied annually in late winter.

It is possible to raise your own rhubarb from seed, but buying a plant, or separating a piece of long root, complete with at least one bud taken from the outside of the parent clump in winter or early spring, is better. Plant out immediately; make sure that the bud is at the same depth as when it was dug out. Allow 36 in (90 cm) space between plants.



Pull stems gently to protect the clump.

CROP CARE

Newly planted rhubarb should be watered during dry spells for the first year. Mulch it with a 3 in (7 cm) layer of organic matter.

FORCING

Forcing your rhubarb results in earlier, sweeter, and more tender stems. Pile organic matter around the forcing container to ensure that no